chaos in part of the East Coast or the area in the radius of 600 to 1000 miles from Cuba." The military shared McNamara's concerns. "The Chiefs are strong in their recommendation against that kind of an attack, believing that it would leave too great a capability undestroyed," McNamara told the president during the evening session. General Taylor added that in the opinion of the chiefs "it would be a mistake to take this very narrow, selective target because it invited reprisal attacks and it may be detrimental." That afternoon, the Joint Chiefs of Staff agreed at their meeting to push for an invasion whether the Soviets had operational nuclear weapons on the island or not.[20]

McNamara disliked Kennedy's surgical strike option but was also critical of the diplomatic option proposed by Rusk, as it would give the Soviets time to build up their nuclear capabilities on the island and prepare for a possible invasion, which he believed could start a nuclear war. He proposed a new course instead: to impose a naval blockade on the island. Rusk's original plan, which he proposed that morning, envisioned a blockade as part of the general strike option, but now McNamara proposed to decouple them. He wanted to issue a statement with the following message: "[W]e would immediately impose a blockade against offensive weapons entering Cuba in the future and indicate that, with our open surveillance reconnaissance which we would plan to maintain indefinitely into the future, we would be immediately prepared to attack the Soviet Union in the event that Cuba made an offensive move against this country."[21]

McNamara's proposal caught many by surprise. It looked as if he were bringing the possibility of nuclear war closer instead of warding it off. "Attack who?" asked Bundy. "The Soviet Union," responded McNamara. He added that his third way "lies short of military action against Cuba." Kennedy was skeptical. On the one hand, he assumed that the proposed statement "would secure a good deal of political support" and "would put the burden on the Soviets." On the other hand, it would complicate the conduct of a military operation. "We would lose all the advantages of our strike," observed Kennedy. He was committed to the strike and had serious reservations about any warning to Khrushchev, public or private. Kennedy